

1950 – 1980

Buoyed by new nationhood, these decades saw a fresh start for the Indian Railways. The political obstacles that had existed under colonial rule had disappeared and a major reorganization of the railways was undertaken, starting with its division into six zones. This period also saw several new technological and institutional changes, a move towards modernization, phasing out of steam, and setting off on the path to electrification.

26 January 1950 The Constitution of India comes into effect, formally establishing India as a Republic. On the same day, Chittaranjan Locomotive Works (CLW) is inaugurated and the Assam Rail Link is opened to passenger traffic. 25 October 1951 The first general elections of India are conducted. 1954 Sleeping accommodation is introduced in third-class coaches.	1956 The first fully air-conditioned train, popularly known as the AC Express, is introduced between Howrah and Delhi. 1959 Fans and lights become standard features in all passenger coaches, including the third class.	20 October 1962 China invades Ladakh and the North East Frontier Agency, starting the Sino-India war. 14 November 1963 CLW rolls out Bidhan, the first entirely India-built electric locomotive.	April 1965 Following Pakistan's Operation Gibraltar, India and Pakistan go to war. 1965 Fast freight services or the "Super Express" are introduced on several routes. 1971 The Indian Railways formulates its gauge conversion policy.	3 March 1968 The Raghun Express, the first high-speed all-AC train, runs between Howrah and New Delhi. 16 December 1971 End of the third Indo-Pak war, which marks the formation of the new nation of Bangladesh. 1972 Construction of the Calcutta Metro begins.	1974 The Rail India Technical and Economic Services (RITES) is incorporated as a public limited company. 26 June 1975 President Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed declares a state of internal Emergency in the country. 21 March 1977 The Emergency in India comes to an end. 1979 The Central Organisation for Railways Electrification (CORE) is formed.
1950–55	1956–61	1962 – 67	1968–73	1974–80	
14 April 1952 The Eastern, Northern, and North Eastern Railways are formed. 1955 Integral Coach Factory at Perambur, Tamil Nadu, is inaugurated. The South Eastern Railway is formed. 1951 The zonal grouping of the railways starts with the creation of the Southern, Western, and Central Railways.	15 January 1958 The Northeast Frontier Railway is formed by splitting the North Eastern Railway. 1961 The CLW starts manufacturing electric locomotives and the Diesel Locomotive Works is set up at Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh. 1957 The Indian Railways decide to adopt 25 KV AC system for electrification. In the same year, the Research Designs and Standards Organisation (RDSD), the Indian Railway Institute for Signal Engineering and Telecommunication (IRISLET), and the Railway Protection Force (RPF) are established.	21 November 1962 The Sino-Indian war comes to an end. September 1965 The second Indo-Pak war ends in a ceasefire. 1964 The CLW builds its first AC locomotive, a WAG-1. 1964 The first container service in India starts between Bombay and Ahmedabad and the South Central Railway is formed.	3 December 1971 India goes to war against Pakistan in support of the Bangladesh Liberation War. 1971 The Taraka Railway Bridge and the Pathankot-Jammu Tawi section is opened. 20 July 1969 Apollo 11 lands on the moon and Neil Armstrong and Edwin Aldrin Jr are the first people to walk on the moon. 1973 CLW stops production of steam locomotives.	1 February 1973 The National Railway Museum (NRM) opens to the public. 1977 Abolition of third-class railway travel. Wooden-seat seats are abolished and a cushioned second-class seating system is made the minimum standard. 3 May 1974 The All India Railwaymen's Federation, led by its president George Fernandes, launches a total strike. The strike is one of the factors that contributes to the imposition of the Emergency in India.	
					
1951 general elections in India	An inauguration at the Chittaranjan Locomotive Works	Locomotive Bidhan	Indian soldiers during the 1971 Indo-Pak war	Builder plates at the National Rail Museum, New Delhi	

“... it was a marriage between the old and the new. This marriage was essential because India could hardly live in an old age. When science was making very fast progress, India ... was making an effort to achieve progress through electrification.”

JAWAHARLAL NEHRU AT THE INAUGURATION OF THE ELECTRIC TRAIN IN CALCUTTA ON 14 DECEMBER 1957